EXCEPTIONALISM OF RAKHINE STATE ELECTION RESULTS

Most analysts of politics in Myanmar, including myself, were not expecting the NLD to get an absolute majority in the national parliament, even though it would win the largest number of seats, or that it would dominate in most State Hluttaws. This prediction was based on two assumptions: political allegiances would go to ethnic parties in the states, and the influence of the Buddhist nationalists who were campaigning against the NLD would be significant. Post-election readings of the NLD's stunning victory risked under-recognizing the continued relevance of these phenomena to Myanmar's political and social conditions.

The first assumption was that most ethnic parties would receive somewhat stronger support in the states (see ICG 2015b; Kyaw San Wai and Kumada 2015; Medail 2015; Nguyen 2015). It was predicted that ethnic parties, with a substantial number of ethnic seats, would become key players at least in state assemblies, if not at the national level. Ethnic groups would vote as a block, overcoming the organizational and financial challenges faced by the ethnic political leaderships (Berliner 2015).

The second assumption was based on the perceived popularity of MaBaTha (Committee for Protection of Race and Religion), which campaigned against the NLD in the election. The rise of Buddhist nationalism, initially as the 969 movement and later as MaBaTha, was linked to the anti-Muslim riots between 2012 and 2014. Starting with the Rakhine riots in June 2012 in Rakhine State, sixteen violent incidents against Muslim communities occurred across the country by June 2014 (Min Zin 2015). Capitalizing on these events and the associated communal sentiments, the Buddhist nationalist movement achieved popularity in Myanmar.

MaBaTha viewed the NLD and its party leader Daw Aung San Suu Kyi as pro-Muslim for their stance on the rule of law and communal tolerance. Moreover, there were reports of weakening support for the NLD throughout the country, especially in 2014. For example, the NLD's signature campaign for amendment of the Constitution received five million signatures from the whole country, which some considered a relatively small proportion of the population (Htoo Thant 2014). Citing large MaBaTha public events and the local rumours, some said that the NLD had lost the sizeable support it enjoyed before 2011. Looking at the popular MaBaTha events, it was assumed that the popularity of Daw Aung San Suu Kyi and the NLD had